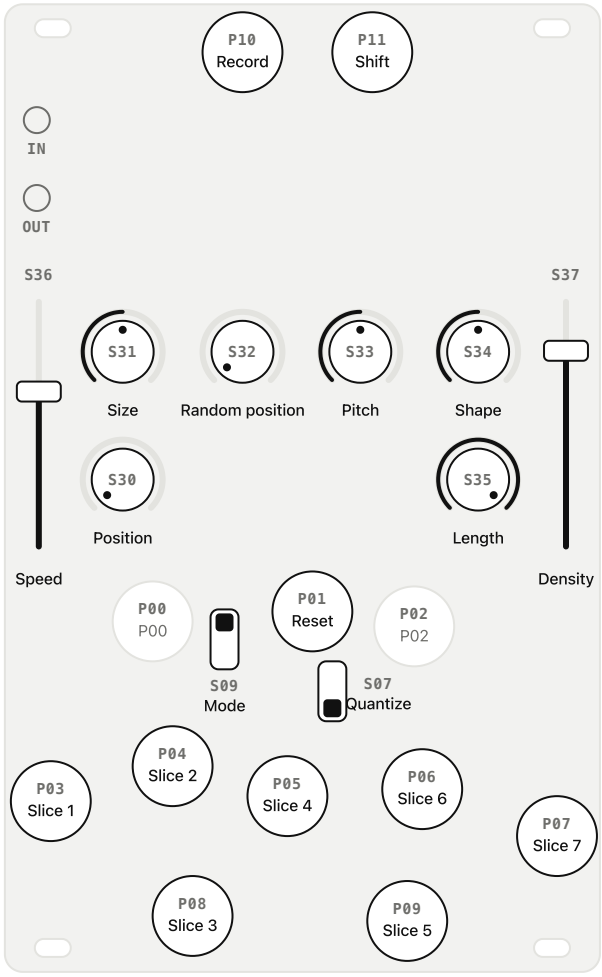
Simple Touch

Clessidra

It's the instrument where you pour grains of sound from single drops into a dense cloud.

francescodimaggio.nl/clessidra

Synthux Design Residency 2026



Record a sound, then play it as grains: Speed through it, Density how they fall.

Two layers: each knob alone, and its twin with P11 held. Nothing jumps when they change.

Density at its centre: no grains but the slices'. S09 at its centre: frozen.

FADERS AND KNOBS

S36	**Speed**. How fast the playhead runs: the time stretched, the pitch kept. Stops at ¼, ½, 1, 2 and 4×. Frozen: scrubs through the loop, the speed taken up again after. *P11*: **Dry/wet**. The input against the grains, equal power.
S37	**Density**. Grains at once, 1/16 to 16. None at the centre. Down: regular, drops to a stream. Up: random, scattered to a cloud. *P11*: **Reverb**. On the grains: none to most, the decay 0.5 to 16 s.
S30	**Position**. Where the loop starts, anywhere in the recording. Frozen: moves the point with it.
S35	**Length**. How long the loop is, past the end round to the start.
S31	**Size**. Grain length, 5 ms to 2 s, 100 ms at the centre, at most half the recording. *P11*: **Random size**. Each grain's size, longer or shorter, up to about two octaves either way.
S32	**Random position**. How far grains stray from the playhead, evenly, up to the whole loop, across the stereo field with it.
S33	**Pitch**. ±24 semitones. Stops at 0, 1, 3, 4, 7, 12, 24. *P11*: **Random pitch**. Each grain's pitch, up to an octave either way, snapped as S07 sets.
S34	**Shape**. The grain's window: reverse percussive down, Hann at the centre, percussive up. *P11*: **Filter**. On the grains: low-pass down to 200 Hz, off at the centre, high-pass up to 2 kHz.

PADS AND SWITCHES

S09	**Mode**. Up forward, centre frozen, down reverse.
S07	**Quantize**. The random pitch: down free, centre in semitones, up in octaves.
P10	**Record**. Tap: the last 8 s. Hold: up to 30 s, the input heard. The new recording pours in over 2 s. With P11: listen, the input heard, nothing recorded.
P11	**Shift**. Held: the knobs' twins. With P01: the twins back to their defaults. With P10: listen.
P01	**Reset**. With P11: the twins back to their defaults, nothing jumps. Alone: nothing yet.
P03–P09	**Slices**. The loop in sevenths, left to right on the board: P03, P04, P08, P05, P09, P06, P07. A touch: the playhead there, a grain at once, the beat from it. Held: it stays there.
P00, P02	Not assigned yet.

TO PLAY

Rhythm	Density below the centre, Shape up, Size short. Tap the slices: each restarts the beat
Drums by hand	Density at the centre: each slice plays one grain
Cloud	Density at the top, Random position up, Size long, Reverb (P11 + S37) up
Stretch	Speed at ¼ or ½, Density up. S09 down to hear it backwards
A moment held	S09 at the centre, Density up, a little Random position. Speed scrubs the point
Shimmer	Random pitch (P11 + S33) up, S07 up: octaves

LED

Glow	Grains falling, dimmer as the sand runs out
Flashing	Recording
Pulse	At a stop: unison, speed 1×, 100 ms, Hann, filter off
Steady	P11 held: the twin last turned